

TIP 1: EXPRESS EMOTION AS AN ACTION

TELL:

Show:

He was mad.

He slammed his glass on the table.

She was excited.

She bounced up and down, singing a happy tune.

TIP 2: USE THE FIVE SENSES

Use the senses to set the scene. What did you see, hear, feel, touch or taste?

TELL:

Show:

It was cold.

My body convulsed as the frigid wind blew.

It was dark.

I traced the rough brick as I felt my way along the hallway.

TIP 3: BE DESCRIPTIVE AND SPECIFIC

Be as specific as possible with your descriptions and actions.

TELL:

Show:

The house was old.

With each step I took, the old house creaked.

I drove fast.

Foot down on the gas pedal, I zoomed through the town, my hair whipping in the breeze.



SHOW DON'T TELL

WORDS TO DESCRIBE TASTE

1. acidic - very sour
2. ambrosia - the food of gods
3. astringent - strong and bitter
4. brackish - a slight taste of salt
5. caustic - biting, acid, sharp
6. delectable - delicious, tasty, mouth-watering
7. dulcet - sweet, honeyed, pleasant
8. mature - a pleasantly strong flavor
9. nectarous - delicious or sweet
10. palatable - edible, pleasant, tasty
11. piquant - savory, spicy, tasty, zesty
12. pungent - overpowering, biting
13. robust - has a lot of flavor
14. saccharine - sugary or syrupy
15. savory - tasting of salt or spices; does not taste sweet
16. sharp - a strong and bitter flavor
17. succulent - juicy, moist, tender, lush
18. syrupy - thick, sweet, and sticky
19. tang - a taste that leaves the tongue tingling
20. tart - a slightly sour taste



SHOW DON'T TELL

WORDS TO DESCRIBE TOUCH

1. abrasive - harsh
2. angular - pointed, v-shaped
3. blistered - painful swelling on the skin
4. bristly - having a stiff and prickly texture
5. embossed - carve, mold, or stamp a design on a surface
6. enamelled - coat or decorate with enamel
7. fluted - grooved or ridged
8. gelatinous - having the consistency of jelly
9. gnarled - difficult, unpleasant, unattractive
10. gossamer - very light, thin, and insubstantial
11. grainy - granular, gritty, coarse
12. impenetrable - impassable, inaccessible, trackless
13. inlaid - ornamented, decorated, studded
14. malleable - pliable, pliant, soft, tensile
15. sandy - light, yellowish brown; easy to work, granular, gritty
16. sheer - gauzy, filmy, floaty
17. unblemished - impeccable, flawless, perfect
18. varnished - shellac, glaze, polish
19. withered - dry, shriveled
20. yielding - giving way under pressure; not hard or rigid



SHOW DON'T TELL

WORDS TO DESCRIBE SOUND

1. brassy - a sound that is loud and unpleasant
2. deafening - a sound so loud you cannot hear anything else
3. dulcet - soft and pleasant
4. emit - to make a sound
5. grinding - a sound of one hard thing moving against another
6. howling - a continuous, low, loud noise
7. hushed - a sound that is quiet
8. lilting - a sound that has a rising and falling pattern
9. melodic - beautiful sound
10. monotonous - a sounds that is always the same
11. muffled- a blocked sound that isn't easy to hear
12. plaintive - a sound that has a sad quality
13. pulsating - strong, regular pattern
14. raucous - rude, violent, noisy
15. resounding - a sound that is loud and that continues for a while
16. rhythmic - a sound that has a clear, regular pattern
17. shrill - a sound that is loud, high, and unpleasant
18. sonorous - a sound that is deep and strong in a pleasant way
19. staccato - a sound where each word or sound is clearly separate
20. tumultuous - a sound that shows noise, excitement, activity, or violence



SHOW DON'T TELL

WORDS TO DESCRIBE SMELLS

1. aroma - a distinctive, pleasant smell
2. aura - atmosphere, air, quality, ambience
3. balm - a fragrant ointment, salve, moisturizer
4. bouquet - aroma, smell, fragrance, perfume
5. doggy - rakish, spry, clean
6. earthy - soil or dirt-like
7. essence - extract, concentrate, elixir
8. flowery - florid, overripe; smelling of flowers
9. fragrance - a pleasant, sweet smell
10. incense - substance that is burned for the sweet smell it produces
11. loamy - related to the fertile soil of clay and sand
12. musty - having a stale, moldy, or damp smell
13. pungent - having a sharply strong taste or smell
14. putrid - decaying or rotting and emitting a fetid smell; rotting, decaying
15. odorize - give an odor or scent to
16. pheromone - a chemical substance produced and released by an animal
17. redolence - an often pungent or agreeable odor
18. stale - no longer fresh or pleasant
19. whiff - a smell that is only smelled briefly or faintly
20. wispy - dim, faint, shadowy, vague, indistinct



SHOW DON'T TELL

WORDS TO DESCRIBE SIGHTS

1. bleary - unfocused or filmy from sleep or tiredness
2. blurred - not clear or distinct; hazy
3. brilliant - very bright and radiant
4. colorless - uncolored, white, faded, washed out
5. dingy - gloomy and drab
6. flashy - ostentatiously attractive or impressive
7. gaudy - extravagantly bright or showy, typically so as to be tasteless
8. gleaming - reflecting light, typically because very clean or polished
9. glimpse - a momentary or partial view
10. glittering - shining with a shimmering or sparkling light
11. glowing - have an intense color and a slight shine
12. gloomy - dark or poorly lit
13. hazy - vague, indistinct, or ill-defined
14. peer - look keenly or with difficulty at someone or something
15. radiant - sending out light; shining or glowing brightly
16. shimmering - shining with a soft, slightly wavering light
17. smudged - make blurred or indistinct
18. streaked - striped, banded, flecked
19. tarnished - discolored, stained, rusted, oxidized
20. twinkling - shining with a gleam that changes from bright to faint



Onomatopoeia: a word that imitates natural sounds.

1. babble - a gentle, pleasant sound of water as it moves along in a river
2. bang - to move, making loud noise
3. beep - a short high sound or several short high sounds
4. blare - to make a loud and unpleasant noise
5. caterwaul - an unpleasant loud high noise
6. chink - a high ringing sound when knocked together
7. clack - to make a short loud sound like one hard object hitting another
8. clatter - a series of short, sharp noise
9. fizz - a soft sound that small gas bubbles make when they burst
10. growl - a low, unpleasant noise
11. gurgle - the low sound water makes when poured quickly from a bottle
12. mewl - crying with a soft, high sound
13. peal - makes a loud sound
14. rumble - a continuous, very loud noise
15. screech - to make a loud, high, and unpleasant noise
16. scrunch - to make a loud noise like something very crush
17. squeal - to make a long, high sound
18. tinkle - to make a high, ringing sound
19. whirr - a fast, repeated, quiet sound
20. yelp - a short, loud, high sound, usually caused by excitement or anger

